MOM'S HOMESTYLE KITCHEN

Mom's Secret Recipes



Time-Tested Comfort Food & Everyday Dinners

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Welcome to My Kitchen

There is something deeply comforting about the sound of a simmering pot on the stove and the aroma of golden butter and onions filling a warm kitchen. For busy families, cooking is not about complicated culinary trends or rare ingredients—it is about turning honest pantry staples into hearty, delicious meals that bring everyone together after a long day.

The recipes in this book are the family favorites I have made week in and week out: the cozy casseroles, the quick skillet suppers, and the weekend treats that my kids always ask for. They are simple, dependable, and designed for real home cooks.

You do not need hours of prep time to put a wholesome, homemade dinner on the table. With a few dependable techniques, a good skillet, and simple ingredients, you can make meals that taste far better than takeout and cost a fraction of the price.

Mom's Golden Rules of the Kitchen

- **Brown is flavor:** Never rush searing meat or sautéing onions. That golden crust is the secret to rich, savory gravies.
- **Keep butter cold for baking:** For tall buttermilk biscuits and flaky crisps, cold butter creates the steam that puffs up the dough.
- **Taste as you go:** A pinch of salt or fresh cracked pepper right before serving brings all the flavors into balance.
- **Gather around the table:** No matter how busy the week gets, dinner together is where the best family memories are made.

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CHAPTER 1

Soups, Stews & Skillet Suppers



Classic Farmhouse Chicken Noodle Soup

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 45 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *The real secret to this soup is browning the vegetables in butter first before adding the broth. It brings out a deep, golden sweetness that bouillon cubes just cannot match.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1 medium yellow onion, diced
- ☐ 3 large carrots, sliced into 1/4-inch (6 mm) coins
- ☐ 3 ribs celery, chopped
- ☐ 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 8 cups (1.9 L) good-quality chicken broth or stock
- ☐ 2 large chicken breasts (approx. 1 lb / 450 g), boneless and skinless
- ☐ 6 oz (170 g) wide homestyle egg noodles
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) dried thyme (or 3 sprigs fresh thyme)
- ☐ 1 bay leaf
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) fine sea salt, to taste
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) freshly cracked black pepper
- ☐ 2 tbsp (6 g) fresh parsley, chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Melt the butter in a large heavy-bottomed Dutch oven over medium heat. Add the chopped onion, carrots, and celery. Cook for 6 to 8 minutes until the vegetables soften and begin to turn golden.
2. **Step 2.** Stir in the minced garlic, thyme, salt, and black pepper. Cook for 1 minute until fragrant.

3. **Step 3.** Pour in the chicken broth and drop in the bay leaf. Add the raw chicken breasts directly into the broth. Bring to a gentle boil, then reduce heat to low, cover with a lid, and simmer for 20 minutes until the chicken reaches an internal temperature of 165 °F (74 °C).
4. **Step 4.** Transfer the chicken breasts to a cutting board. Shred into bite-sized pieces using two forks.
5. **Step 5.** Increase heat to medium-low and stir the egg noodles into the simmering broth. Cook uncovered for 7 to 9 minutes until the noodles are tender.
6. **Step 6.** Return the shredded chicken to the pot. Discard the bay leaf, stir in the fresh parsley, and adjust salt and pepper to taste before ladling into warm bowls.

Slow-Simmered Old-Fashioned Beef Stew

PREP: 20 MINS • **COOK: 1 HR 45 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Tough cuts of beef need patience and low heat. Do not crowd the pan when searing the meat; getting a deep brown crust on the beef creates the rich foundation of the gravy.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 2 lbs (900 g) beef chuck roast, trimmed and cut into 1.5-inch (4 cm) cubes
- ☐ 1/4 cup (32 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) vegetable oil or lard
- ☐ 1 large yellow onion, coarsely chopped
- ☐ 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 2 tbsp (32 g) tomato paste
- ☐ 4 cups (950 ml) low-sodium beef broth
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) red wine or extra beef broth
- ☐ 1 lb (450 g) baby Yukon Gold potatoes, halved
- ☐ 4 large carrots, peeled and cut into 1-inch (2.5 cm) chunks
- ☐ 1 tsp (1 g) dried rosemary
- ☐ 1 tsp (1 g) dried thyme
- ☐ 2 dried bay leaves
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) salt and 1/2 tsp cracked black pepper
- ☐ 1 cup (150 g) frozen sweet peas

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Pat the beef cubes dry with paper towels. Toss the meat in a bowl with the flour, 1 tsp salt, and 1/2 tsp black pepper until evenly coated.
2. **Step 2.** Heat 2 tbsp oil in a large Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Sear the beef in two batches for 3 to 4 minutes per side until deeply browned. Transfer the seared beef

to a plate.

3. **Step 3.** In the same pot, reduce heat to medium and add the chopped onion. Cook for 4 minutes until translucent. Add minced garlic and tomato paste, stirring constantly for 1 minute.
4. **Step 4.** Pour in the red wine (or 1 cup broth) to deglaze the pot, scraping up all the caramelized browned bits from the bottom with a wooden spoon.
5. **Step 5.** Return the beef and any resting juices to the pot. Pour in the remaining beef broth, rosemary, thyme, and bay leaves. Bring to a boil, then cover tightly, reduce heat to low, and simmer gently for 1 hour.
6. **Step 6.** Add the halved potatoes and carrots. Cover and simmer for an additional 40 minutes until the beef and vegetables are fork-tender.
7. **Step 7.** Stir in the frozen peas during the final 5 minutes of cooking. Remove bay leaves, taste and adjust seasoning, and serve hot with crusty bread.

Homestyle Roasted Tomato Basil Soup

PREP: 10 MINS • **COOK:** 30 MINS • **YIELD:** 4 SERVINGS

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *A pinch of baking soda cuts through tomato acidity without needing piles of sugar. Serve this alongside buttery golden grilled cheese sandwiches for the ultimate rainy-day lunch.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 2 cans (28 oz / 800 g each) whole peeled San Marzano tomatoes, with juice
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) olive oil
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1 large sweet onion, finely chopped
- ☐ 4 cloves garlic, smashed and peeled
- ☐ 2 cups (480 ml) vegetable or chicken broth
- ☐ 1/2 cup (120 ml) heavy whipping cream (or whole milk)
- ☐ 1/4 cup (10 g) fresh basil leaves, tightly packed
- ☐ 1/4 tsp baking soda (balances acidity)
- ☐ 1 tsp (4 g) sugar
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) sea salt and 1/4 tsp freshly cracked black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Heat the olive oil and butter in a large soup pot over medium heat. Add the chopped sweet onion and cook for 6 to 8 minutes until soft and fragrant.
2. **Step 2.** Add the smashed garlic cloves and cook for 1 minute until fragrant.
3. **Step 3.** Pour in the canned tomatoes with their juice, crushing them lightly with a wooden spoon. Add the broth, sugar, baking soda, salt, and black pepper. Bring to a gentle boil.
4. **Step 4.** Reduce heat to low, cover partially, and simmer for 20 minutes to allow the flavors to meld.

5. **Step 5.** Remove from heat and stir in the fresh basil leaves. Use an immersion hand blender (or blend in batches in a countertop blender) until velvety smooth.
6. **Step 6.** Stir in the heavy whipping cream, taste for seasoning, and serve immediately topped with fresh cracked pepper and basil ribbons.

Hearty Cast-Iron Chicken Pot Pie Skillet

PREP: 20 MINS • **COOK: 35 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Making this in a cast-iron skillet saves washing multiple pans and gives you an intensely flaky, golden puff pastry crust right out of the oven.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 3 cups (450 g) cooked shredded chicken (rotisserie or roasted)
- ☐ 4 tbsp (60 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1 medium yellow onion, diced
- ☐ 2 medium carrots, diced
- ☐ 2 ribs celery, diced
- ☐ 1/3 cup (42 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 2 cups (480 ml) low-sodium chicken broth
- ☐ 3/4 cup (180 ml) whole milk or heavy cream
- ☐ 1 cup (150 g) frozen peas and sweet corn mix
- ☐ 1/2 tsp dried thyme and 1/4 tsp dried poultry seasoning
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) salt and 1/2 tsp black pepper
- ☐ 1 sheet frozen puff pastry (or refrigerated pie crust), thawed
- ☐ 1 large egg beaten with 1 tbsp water (egg wash)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat your oven to 400 °F (200 °C).
2. **Step 2.** In a 10-inch or 12-inch oven-safe cast iron skillet, melt the butter over medium heat. Add the diced onion, carrots, and celery. Sauté for 6 to 8 minutes until softened.
3. **Step 3.** Sprinkle the flour over the vegetables and stir constantly for 2 minutes to cook out the raw flour taste.

4. **Step 4.** Slowly whisk in the chicken broth and milk, whisking continuously to prevent lumps. Simmer for 3 to 5 minutes until the gravy thickens to a glossy consistency.
5. **Step 5.** Stir in the shredded chicken, frozen peas and corn, thyme, poultry seasoning, salt, and pepper. Remove the skillet from heat.
6. **Step 6.** Unroll the sheet of puff pastry and drape it directly over the hot filling in the skillet, tucking the edges inward. Cut three 1-inch slits in the center to allow steam to escape.
7. **Step 7.** Brush the top generously with the beaten egg wash. Bake at 400 °F (200 °C) for 25 to 30 minutes until the pastry is puffed and deeply golden brown. Let rest for 10 minutes before serving.

Traditional Sunday Skillet Beef Chili

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 45 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *A touch of unsweetened cocoa powder and ground cumin gives homestyle chili an earthy, authentic warmth that makes everyone ask for seconds.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1.5 lbs (680 g) lean ground beef (85/15)
- ☐ 1 large yellow onion, diced
- ☐ 1 green bell pepper, diced
- ☐ 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 2 tbsp (16 g) chili powder
- ☐ 1 tbsp (7 g) ground cumin
- ☐ 1 tsp (3 g) smoked paprika
- ☐ 1 tbsp (6 g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- ☐ 1 can (28 oz / 800 g) crushed tomatoes
- ☐ 1 can (15 oz / 425 g) dark red kidney beans, rinsed and drained
- ☐ 1 can (15 oz / 425 g) black beans, rinsed and drained
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) beef broth
- ☐ 1 tsp salt and 1/2 tsp black pepper
- ☐ Toppings: shredded cheddar cheese, sour cream, sliced green onions

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** In a large heavy pot or Dutch oven, brown the ground beef over medium-high heat, breaking it apart with a wooden spoon, for 6 to 8 minutes until no longer pink. Drain excess fat if desired.
2. **Step 2.** Add the diced onion, green bell pepper, and garlic to the beef. Sauté for 5 minutes until the vegetables are tender.

3. **Step 3.** Stir in the chili powder, cumin, smoked paprika, cocoa powder, salt, and pepper. Toast the spices with the meat for 1 minute.
4. **Step 4.** Add the crushed tomatoes, rinsed kidney beans, black beans, and beef broth. Stir well to combine.
5. **Step 5.** Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to low. Cover loosely and simmer gently for 35 to 40 minutes, stirring occasionally so it does not stick to the bottom.
6. **Step 6.** Ladle into bowls and serve piping hot with shredded sharp cheddar cheese, sour cream, and homemade cornbread.

CHAPTER 2

Sunday Roasts & Casseroles



Classic Brown Sugar Glazed Meatloaf

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 1 HR** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Soaking breadcrumbs in milk before mixing keeps the meat tender and prevents the loaf from drying out in the oven. Never pack the meat tightly; a light touch yields the best texture.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 2 lbs (900 g) ground beef (or half beef, half pork)
- ☐ 3/4 cup (60 g) plain breadcrumbs
- ☐ 1/2 cup (120 ml) whole milk
- ☐ 1 small yellow onion, finely grated or diced
- ☐ 2 large eggs, lightly beaten
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) Worcestershire sauce
- ☐ 2 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) salt and 1/2 tsp black pepper
- ☐ 1 tsp (1 g) dried Italian parsley
- ☐ Glaze: 1/2 cup (120 ml) ketchup, 2 tbsp (26 g) brown sugar, 1 tbsp (15 ml) apple cider vinegar, 1/2 tsp garlic powder

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 350 °F (175 °C). Line a rimmed baking sheet with aluminum foil or parchment paper.
2. **Step 2.** In a small bowl, combine the breadcrumbs and milk; let sit for 5 minutes until the milk is absorbed.
3. **Step 3.** In a large mixing bowl, gently combine the ground beef, soaked breadcrumbs, grated onion, beaten eggs, Worcestershire sauce, minced garlic, salt, pepper, and parsley. Mix gently with your hands just until combined—do not overwork.
4. **Step 4.** Shape the mixture into a 9x5-inch loaf onto the prepared baking sheet.

5. **Step 5.** In a small bowl, whisk together the ketchup, brown sugar, apple cider vinegar, and garlic powder. Brush half of this glaze evenly over the top and sides of the meatloaf.
6. **Step 6.** Bake at 350 °F (175 °C) for 40 minutes. Remove from the oven, spoon the remaining glaze over the top, and bake for an additional 15 to 20 minutes until the internal temperature reaches 160 °F (71 °C).
7. **Step 7.** Let the meatloaf rest for 10 minutes before slicing so the flavorful juices settle.

Tender Melt-in-Your-Mouth Sunday Pot Roast

PREP: 20 MINS • **COOK: 3 HRS** • **YIELD: 8 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *A heavy chuck roast cooked low and slow with beef stock and aromatic herbs transforms into the most succulent dinner of the week. The pan drippings make liquid gold gravy.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 3.5 lbs (1.6 kg) boneless beef chuck roast, well-marbled
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) olive oil or vegetable oil
- ☐ 1 tbsp (15 g) kosher salt and 1 tsp freshly ground black pepper
- ☐ 2 medium yellow onions, peeled and quartered
- ☐ 5 large carrots, cut into 2-inch (5 cm) chunks
- ☐ 1.5 lbs (680 g) baby red or Yukon gold potatoes, scrubbed
- ☐ 4 cloves garlic, smashed
- ☐ 2 cups (480 ml) rich beef bone broth
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) dry red wine (or extra beef broth)
- ☐ 2 tbsp (32 g) tomato paste
- ☐ 3 sprigs fresh rosemary and 4 sprigs fresh thyme
- ☐ 2 bay leaves

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 300 °F (150 °C).
2. **Step 2.** Pat the roast dry with paper towels. Season aggressively on all sides with kosher salt and black pepper.
3. **Step 3.** Heat 2 tbsp oil in a large Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Sear the roast for 5 minutes per side until a rich, dark brown crust forms on all surfaces. Transfer the

meat to a platter.

4. **Step 4.** Add the quartered onions to the pot and cook for 3 to 4 minutes until browned at the edges. Add the garlic and tomato paste; stir for 1 minute.
5. **Step 5.** Pour in the red wine (or broth), scraping up all the savory browned bits from the bottom. Add the beef broth, rosemary, thyme sprigs, and bay leaves.
6. **Step 6.** Return the roast to the pot, nestling it in the liquid. Cover tightly with a heavy lid and transfer to the preheated oven for 2 hours.
7. **Step 7.** Carefully remove the pot from the oven, arrange the carrots and potatoes around the meat, cover again, and return to the oven for an additional 1 hour, or until the beef pulls apart effortlessly with a fork.
8. **Step 8.** Discard the herb stems and bay leaves. Slice or shred the beef and serve surrounded by tender vegetables with the pan juices spooned on top.

Country Shepherd's Pie with Golden Mashed Potato Crust

PREP: 25 MINS • **COOK: 35 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Broiling the mashed potato peaks during the last two minutes creates those irresistible crispy, golden-brown ridges that everyone fights over at the dinner table.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1.5 lbs (680 g) lean ground beef or ground lamb
- ☐ 1 large onion, finely chopped
- ☐ 2 medium carrots, peeled and diced small
- ☐ 2 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 2 tbsp (16 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 2 tbsp (32 g) tomato paste
- ☐ 1.5 cups (360 ml) beef broth
- ☐ 1 tbsp (15 ml) Worcestershire sauce
- ☐ 1 cup (150 g) frozen peas and corn mix
- ☐ 1 tsp salt and 1/2 tsp black pepper
- ☐ Mashed potato topping: 2 lbs (900 g) Russet potatoes, peeled and quartered; 4 tbsp (60 g) butter; 1/3 cup (80 ml) warm milk; 1/2 cup (50 g) shredded sharp cheddar cheese; salt and pepper to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Boil the quartered potatoes in salted water for 15 minutes until fork-tender. Drain well and mash thoroughly with butter, warm milk, salt, and pepper until smooth.
2. **Step 2.** Meanwhile, preheat oven to 375 °F (190 °C).

3. **Step 3.** In a large skillet over medium-high heat, brown the ground meat with the onion and carrots for 8 minutes until the meat is cooked through. Drain excess grease.
4. **Step 4.** Stir in minced garlic, salt, and pepper, cooking for 1 minute. Sprinkle the flour over the meat and stir for 1 minute.
5. **Step 5.** Stir in tomato paste, Worcestershire sauce, and beef broth. Simmer for 5 minutes until thickened into a glossy gravy. Stir in frozen peas and corn.
6. **Step 6.** Spread the meat filling evenly into an 8x11-inch baking dish (or keep in an oven-safe skillet). Spoon the warm mashed potatoes over the top, smoothing with a spatula and using a fork to create decorative ridges.
7. **Step 7.** Sprinkle with shredded cheddar cheese. Bake at 375 °F (190 °C) for 25 minutes until bubbly, then broil on high for 2 to 3 minutes until the potato peaks are golden brown. Let rest 10 minutes before dishing out.

Ultra-Creamy Four-Cheese Baked Macaroni

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK:** 25 MINS • **YIELD:** 8 SERVINGS

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Always grate your own cheese from blocks! Pre-shredded cheese is coated in anti-caking cellulose powder that prevents the sauce from becoming velvety smooth.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1 lb (450 g) elbow macaroni or cavatappi pasta
- ☐ 1/2 cup (115 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1/2 cup (64 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 4 cups (950 ml) whole milk, warmed
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) heavy cream
- ☐ 3 cups (300 g) sharp cheddar cheese, freshly shredded
- ☐ 1.5 cups (150 g) Gruyère or Monterey Jack cheese, shredded
- ☐ 1/2 cup (50 g) grated Parmesan cheese
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) dry ground mustard powder
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) garlic powder
- ☐ 1/4 tsp cayenne pepper (optional, for depth)
- ☐ 1 tsp salt and 1/2 tsp freshly cracked black pepper
- ☐ Panko crust: 1 cup panko breadcrumbs tossed with 2 tbsp melted butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 350 °F (175 °C). Grease a 9x13-inch baking dish.
2. **Step 2.** Cook the macaroni in a large pot of salted boiling water for 1 minute less than package directions (al dente). Drain and set aside.

3. **Step 3.** In the same pot, melt the butter over medium heat. Whisk in the flour and cook for 1 to 2 minutes, whisking constantly until pale and bubbly.
4. **Step 4.** Slowly pour in the warm milk and heavy cream in a steady stream, whisking vigorously to avoid lumps. Cook over medium heat for 5 to 7 minutes until the white sauce thickens and coats the back of a spoon.
5. **Step 5.** Remove the pot from the heat. Whisk in the dry mustard, garlic powder, cayenne, salt, and black pepper. Stir in 2.5 cups of cheddar, all the Gruyère, and Parmesan until completely melted and smooth.
6. **Step 6.** Fold the drained pasta into the cheese sauce until thoroughly coated. Pour half the mixture into the prepared baking dish, sprinkle with the remaining cheddar, and pour the rest on top.
7. **Step 7.** Top evenly with the buttered panko breadcrumbs. Bake for 20 to 25 minutes until bubbling around the edges and golden on top. Let stand 5 minutes before serving.

CHAPTER 3

Quick Weeknight Dinners & Comfort Classics



Golden Cast-Iron Garlic Butter Pork Chops

PREP: 10 MINS • **COOK: 15 MINS** • **YIELD: 4 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Basting the chops repeatedly with melted butter, crushed garlic, and fresh rosemary during the last few minutes gives you steakhouse tenderness at a fraction of the cost.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 4 bone-in pork rib chops (approx. 1 inch / 2.5 cm thick)
- ☐ 1.5 tbsp (22 ml) olive oil
- ☐ 3 tbsp (45 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 4 cloves garlic, crushed
- ☐ 3 sprigs fresh rosemary or thyme
- ☐ 1 tsp (3 g) garlic powder
- ☐ 1 tsp (3 g) smoked paprika
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) fine sea salt
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) freshly cracked black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Remove pork chops from the refrigerator 20 minutes before cooking to bring them to room temperature. Pat completely dry with paper towels.
2. **Step 2.** In a small ramekin, mix the garlic powder, smoked paprika, salt, and black pepper. Rub the seasoning generously all over both sides of the pork chops.
3. **Step 3.** Heat the olive oil in a heavy 12-inch cast iron skillet over medium-high heat until shimmering.
4. **Step 4.** Add the pork chops and sear undisturbed for 4 to 5 minutes until a deep golden-brown crust develops. Flip the chops.
5. **Step 5.** Immediately add the butter, crushed garlic cloves, and rosemary sprigs to the skillet. Tilt the pan slightly and use a large spoon to baste the foaming garlic butter

over the chops continuously for 3 to 4 minutes.

6. **Step 6.** Cook until the thickest part registers 145 °F (63 °C) on an instant-read meat thermometer.
7. **Step 7.** Transfer the chops to a warm cutting board, pour the remaining pan butter over them, and let rest for 5 minutes before serving.

Crispy Salisbury Steak with Rich Mushroom Onion Gravy

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 20 MINS** • **YIELD: 4 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *This is retro diner comfort food at its absolute best. The savory beef patties simmer right inside the sweet caramelized onion and mushroom gravy.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ Patties: 1.5 lbs (680 g) ground beef (85/15), 1/2 cup breadcrumbs, 1 large egg, 2 tbsp ketchup, 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce, 1 tsp onion powder, 1/2 tsp salt, 1/4 tsp pepper
- ☐ Gravy: 2 tbsp unsalted butter, 1 large yellow onion (thinly sliced), 8 oz (225 g) cremini mushrooms (sliced), 2 cloves garlic (minced)
- ☐ 2 tbsp (16 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 2 cups (480 ml) beef broth
- ☐ 1 tbsp (15 ml) Worcestershire sauce
- ☐ 1 tsp (5 ml) Dijon mustard
- ☐ 1 tbsp chopped fresh parsley for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** In a medium bowl, combine all patty ingredients. Gently mix with your hands until combined. Shape into 4 oval patties about 3/4-inch thick.
2. **Step 2.** Heat 1 tbsp oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Sear the patties for 3 to 4 minutes per side until browned on the exterior. Transfer patties to a plate (they will finish cooking in the gravy).
3. **Step 3.** In the same skillet, melt the butter over medium heat. Add the sliced onions and mushrooms. Sauté for 6 to 8 minutes until golden brown and caramelized.
4. **Step 4.** Add the minced garlic and sprinkle flour over the vegetables, stirring for 1 minute.

5. **Step 5.** Slowly whisk in the beef broth, Worcestershire sauce, and Dijon mustard. Bring to a simmer, scraping up all browned bits, until the gravy begins to thicken.
6. **Step 6.** Nestle the seared patties back into the simmering gravy. Cover and cook over low heat for 8 to 10 minutes until the beef patties are cooked through (160 °F / 71 °C).
7. **Step 7.** Garnish with chopped parsley and serve generously ladled over mashed potatoes or buttered egg noodles.

Old-Fashioned Beef & Macaroni Goulash

PREP: 10 MINS • **COOK: 25 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *A true American weeknight staple made in a single pot. The elbow macaroni cooks directly in the tomato-herb broth, soaking up every bit of seasoned beef flavor.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1.5 lbs (680 g) ground beef
- ☐ 1 large yellow onion, chopped
- ☐ 1 green bell pepper, chopped
- ☐ 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 1 can (28 oz / 800 g) crushed tomatoes
- ☐ 1 can (15 oz / 425 g) diced tomatoes with juice
- ☐ 2 cups (480 ml) beef broth
- ☐ 2 tbsp (30 ml) Worcestershire sauce
- ☐ 2 tsp (4 g) Italian seasoning
- ☐ 1 tsp (3 g) garlic powder
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) salt and 1/2 tsp black pepper
- ☐ 2 cups (200 g) uncooked elbow macaroni
- ☐ 1 cup (100 g) shredded cheddar or Monterey Jack cheese

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** In a large Dutch oven or deep skillet, cook the ground beef, onion, and bell pepper over medium-high heat for 6 to 8 minutes until the beef is browned and vegetables are tender. Drain excess grease.
2. **Step 2.** Add the minced garlic, Italian seasoning, garlic powder, salt, and pepper; stir for 1 minute.

3. **Step 3.** Pour in the crushed tomatoes, diced tomatoes with their juice, beef broth, and Worcestershire sauce. Stir well and bring to a boil.
4. **Step 4.** Add the uncooked elbow macaroni, stirring thoroughly to submerge the pasta.
5. **Step 5.** Cover tightly with a lid, reduce heat to low, and simmer for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring once or twice, until the macaroni is tender and has absorbed the rich tomato broth.
6. **Step 6.** Remove from heat, sprinkle the shredded cheese over the top, and cover for 2 minutes until the cheese is completely melted. Serve immediately.

CHAPTER 4

Farmhouse Sides, Breads & Gravies



Mile-High Southern Buttermilk Biscuits

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 15 MINS** • **YIELD: 8 TALL BISCUITS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Keep your butter freezing cold! When cold butter melts in a hot oven, it releases bursts of steam that create those towering, tender, flaky layers.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 2.5 cups (320 g) all-purpose flour (plus extra for dusting)
- ☐ 1 tbsp (14 g) baking powder
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (3 g) baking soda
- ☐ 1 tsp (6 g) fine salt
- ☐ 1 tbsp (12 g) granulated sugar
- ☐ 1/2 cup (1 stick / 115 g) very cold unsalted butter, cubed or grated
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) cold whole buttermilk (plus 2 tbsp for brushing)
- ☐ 2 tbsp melted butter for brushing tops after baking

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 425 °F (220 °C). Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.
2. **Step 2.** In a large bowl, whisk together the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and sugar.
3. **Step 3.** Add the cold butter cubes. Use a pastry cutter or your fingertips to work the butter into the flour until coarse crumbs form with pea-sized pieces of butter remaining.
4. **Step 4.** Pour in the cold buttermilk. Stir gently with a fork just until a shaggy dough begins to come together. Do not overmix.
5. **Step 5.** Turn the dough onto a lightly floured surface. Gently pat into a 1/2-inch thick rectangle. Fold the dough in thirds like a letter, rotate 90 degrees, and gently pat out again. Repeat this folding process 3 times to build flaky layers.

6. **Step 6.** Pat the dough to a 3/4-inch to 1-inch thickness. Use a floured 2.5-inch round cutter to cut biscuits straight down without twisting (twisting seals the edges and prevents rising).
7. **Step 7.** Arrange biscuits on the baking sheet touching each other (this helps them rise high). Brush tops lightly with buttermilk.
8. **Step 8.** Bake at 425 °F (220 °C) for 14 to 16 minutes until tall and golden brown. Brush immediately with melted butter.

Golden Skillet Honey Butter Cornbread

PREP: 10 MINS • **COOK: 22 MINS** • **YIELD: 8 WEDGES**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Pouring the batter into a preheated, sizzling cast-iron skillet creates that crispy, buttery Southern crust that holds up to chili and stew.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1 cup (150 g) yellow cornmeal
- ☐ 1 cup (125 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 1/3 cup (70 g) granulated sugar
- ☐ 1 tbsp (14 g) baking powder
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (3 g) salt
- ☐ 1 cup (240 ml) whole buttermilk (or whole milk)
- ☐ 2 large eggs, lightly beaten
- ☐ 1/2 cup (115 g) unsalted butter, melted and cooled (plus 2 tbsp for greasing skillet)
- ☐ 3 tbsp (45 ml) honey
- ☐ Honey butter topping: 3 tbsp softened butter whipped with 1 tbsp honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Place a 9-inch or 10-inch cast iron skillet inside the oven and preheat to 400 °F (200 °C).
2. **Step 2.** In a large mixing bowl, whisk together the cornmeal, flour, sugar, baking powder, and salt.
3. **Step 3.** In a separate bowl, whisk the buttermilk, eggs, melted butter, and honey until smooth.
4. **Step 4.** Pour the wet ingredients into the dry ingredients and stir gently with a rubber spatula just until combined (small lumps are fine).
5. **Step 5.** Carefully remove the hot skillet from the oven with an oven mitt. Add 2 tbsp of butter directly to the hot pan, swirling to coat the bottom and sides.

6. **Step 6.** Immediately pour the batter into the hot, sizzling skillet and smooth the top.
7. **Step 7.** Bake at 400 °F (200 °C) for 20 to 22 minutes until golden on top and a toothpick inserted in the center comes out clean.
8. **Step 8.** Serve warm with whipped honey butter.

Velvety Roasted Garlic Mashed Potatoes

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 20 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Simmering the minced garlic in the butter and cream first infuses the dairy with a rich, nutty flavor, so every single spoonful tastes like holiday perfection.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 3 lbs (1.4 kg) Yukon Gold potatoes, peeled and cut into equal 1.5-inch (4 cm) chunks
- ☐ 1/2 cup (1 stick / 115 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 3/4 cup (180 ml) warm whole milk or heavy cream
- ☐ 4 cloves garlic, minced
- ☐ 4 oz (115 g) cream cheese, softened
- ☐ 1.5 tsp (9 g) sea salt (plus salt for boiling water)
- ☐ 1/2 tsp (1 g) freshly cracked black pepper
- ☐ 2 tbsp fresh chives or parsley, finely minced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Place the cut potatoes in a large pot and cover with cold water by at least 1 inch. Add 1 tbsp salt.
2. **Step 2.** Bring to a boil over high heat, then reduce to medium and cook for 15 to 18 minutes until potatoes are completely tender when pierced with a fork. Drain well in a colander.
3. **Step 3.** While potatoes drain, return the warm pot to low heat. Melt the butter and add the minced garlic. Sauté gently for 1 minute until fragrant (do not brown).
4. **Step 4.** Pour in the milk and cream cheese, stirring until smooth and warm.
5. **Step 5.** Return the drained hot potatoes to the pot. Mash with a potato masher until creamy and lump-free (do not use a food processor, which makes potatoes gummy).
6. **Step 6.** Season with 1.5 tsp salt and black pepper. Stir gently to incorporate.

7. **Step 7.** Transfer to a warm serving bowl, create swirls with the back of a spoon, drizzle with extra melted butter, and garnish with fresh chives.

CHAPTER 5

Heritage Pies, Bakes & Sweet Treats

Warm Cinnamon Deep-Dish Apple Crisp

PREP: 20 MINS • **COOK: 40 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *A mix of sweet and tart apples (like Honeycrisp and Granny Smith) gives the filling incredible depth. The brown sugar oat topping bakes into a crunchy, caramelized crust.*

INGREDIENTS

☐ Apple filling: 6 large firm apples (mix of Granny Smith and Honeycrisp), peeled, cored, and sliced 1/4-inch thick; 2 tbsp lemon juice; 1/4 cup (50 g) granulated sugar; 1 tsp ground cinnamon; 1 tbsp cornstarch

☐ Crisp topping: 1 cup (90 g) old-fashioned rolled oats; 1/2 cup (64 g) all-purpose flour; 1/2 cup (100 g) packed brown sugar; 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon; 1/4 tsp salt; 1/2 cup (1 stick / 115 g) cold unsalted butter, cut into small cubes

☐ Serving: Vanilla bean ice cream

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 350 °F (175 °C). Butter an 8x8-inch or 9-inch round baking dish.
2. **Step 2.** In a large bowl, toss the sliced apples with lemon juice, granulated sugar, cinnamon, and cornstarch until evenly coated. Spread the apples into the prepared baking dish.
3. **Step 3.** In a separate bowl, combine the rolled oats, flour, brown sugar, cinnamon, and salt.
4. **Step 4.** Add the cold cubed butter. Work the butter into the dry mixture with your fingertips or a pastry blender until pea-sized crumbly clusters form.
5. **Step 5.** Scatter the oat topping evenly over the apples, covering them completely.
6. **Step 6.** Bake at 350 °F (175 °C) for 38 to 42 minutes until the fruit is bubbling vigorously and the oat topping is deeply golden brown and crunchy.

7. **Step 7.** Let cool for 10 minutes, then spoon into bowls warm from the oven topped with a generous scoop of vanilla ice cream.

Old-Fashioned Southern Peach Cobbler

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK: 40 MINS** • **YIELD: 6 SERVINGS**

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Do not stir the batter into the melted butter! Pouring the batter directly over the melted butter in the pan allows the cake to magically rise through the warm peaches as it bakes.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1/2 cup (1 stick / 115 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1 cup (125 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 1 cup (200 g) granulated sugar
- ☐ 1 tbsp (14 g) baking powder
- ☐ 1/4 tsp salt
- ☐ 3/4 cup (180 ml) whole milk
- ☐ 1 tsp (5 ml) pure vanilla extract
- ☐ Peach filling: 4 cups sliced peaches (fresh, or drained canned/frozen); 1/3 cup brown sugar; 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon; 1/4 tsp ground nutmeg; 1 tbsp lemon juice

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 350 °F (175 °C).
2. **Step 2.** Place the 1/2 cup butter into a 9x13-inch baking dish and place the dish in the oven for 3 to 5 minutes to melt the butter completely. Remove from oven.
3. **Step 3.** In a medium saucepan, combine the sliced peaches, brown sugar, cinnamon, nutmeg, and lemon juice. Heat over medium for 4 minutes until warm and juices release.
4. **Step 4.** In a mixing bowl, whisk together the flour, granulated sugar, baking powder, and salt. Whisk in the milk and vanilla extract until a smooth batter forms.
5. **Step 5.** Pour the batter directly over the melted butter in the baking dish. DO NOT STIR.

6. **Step 6.** Spoon the warm peaches and their juices evenly over the batter. DO NOT STIR.
7. **Step 7.** Bake at 350 °F (175 °C) for 38 to 42 minutes until the golden crust has risen up around the peaches and the center is set.
8. **Step 8.** Serve warm with vanilla ice cream or freshly whipped cream.

Fudgy Double Chocolate Cast-Iron Brownies

PREP: 15 MINS • **COOK:** 25 MINS • **YIELD:** 9 SQUARES

> **MOM'S NOTE:** *Whipping the eggs and sugar together for two full minutes creates that signature papery, crackly shiny crust on top of these rich, dense brownies.*

INGREDIENTS

- ☐ 1/2 cup (1 stick / 115 g) unsalted butter
- ☐ 1 cup (200 g) granulated sugar
- ☐ 2 large eggs, room temperature
- ☐ 1 tsp (5 ml) pure vanilla extract
- ☐ 1/3 cup (35 g) unsweetened Dutch-process cocoa powder
- ☐ 1/2 cup (64 g) all-purpose flour
- ☐ 1/4 tsp salt
- ☐ 3/4 cup (130 g) semi-sweet chocolate chips (divided)
- ☐ Flaky sea salt for sprinkling on top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Step 1.** Preheat oven to 350 °F (175 °C). Grease an 8-inch cast-iron skillet or an 8x8-inch baking pan.
2. **Step 2.** In a microwave-safe bowl (or small saucepan), melt the butter and 1/4 cup of the chocolate chips together until smooth.
3. **Step 3.** In a mixing bowl, beat the granulated sugar, eggs, and vanilla extract with a whisk vigorously for 2 full minutes until pale and slightly thickened.
4. **Step 4.** Whisk the melted butter-chocolate mixture into the eggs.

5. **Step 5.** Gently fold in the cocoa powder, flour, and salt with a rubber spatula just until combined.
6. **Step 6.** Fold in the remaining 1/2 cup of chocolate chips.
7. **Step 7.** Spread the batter into the prepared skillet. Sprinkle lightly with flaky sea salt.
8. **Step 8.** Bake at 350 °F (175 °C) for 22 to 25 minutes until a toothpick inserted in the center comes out with moist crumbs (do not overbake). Let cool 15 minutes before slicing warm.